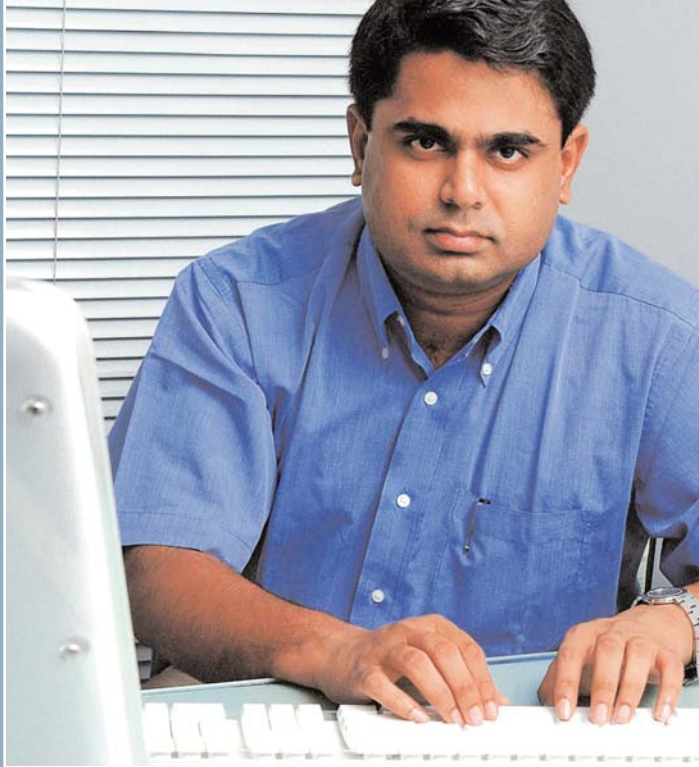




“Convergence can often be a daunting word, where more is misunderstood than understood”

Sachin Kalbag is Executive Editor of Digit

These are questions that require answers derived from evidence gathered over a period of time. Yet, we all know that convergence is where we are headed. It is as if we are in a primordial soup of technological evolution, where cell phones are still cell phones (add a small camera here and a small PDA there), MFDs still do only four functions at most, and personal entertainment gadgets are still just that—personal entertainment gadgets.

The time, therefore, has come to create a revolutionary product. Very few technology products have changed the course of history. The last time a product did that was the personal computer, and that was in the 1970s. The ‘big ticket’ product prior to the computer was the television, in the 1920s. And around 30 years prior to that came the radio.

Nearly 30 years after the PC, therefore, we are due for one more revolution.

Some say the Sony PlayStation Portable is the ultimate converged tool. How shortsighted can we be? The PSP is a glorified personal entertainment gadget. It gives you gaming, it gives you good video, and it gives you great audio. At best, it is an iPod killer; at worst, it is the first step to the ultimate convergence tool—the OmniPerpetual Machine, as I would like to term it.

The OmniPerpetual Machine (or OPM, or Opium!) would do just about everything you ever wanted the ultimate convergence tool to be—a PC, a personal entertainment gadget, a credit card, a mobile phone, a camera, a printer, a scanner, a fax, a copier, an instant messenger, a pager, the works. I can already see the headlines: “Opium is the opiate of the masses.” Marx just turned in his grave.

The Opium is your car key, your personal information databank, your personal banker. It connects to the Internet to give you the latest tax information,

Convergence As The Opiate Of The Masses

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In the beginning was the singularity—the physical state of being everything, yet nothing. A state of being so dense that the entire universe was all of one dot. Just then, the big bang happened. And the universe was created.

The singularity, in a sense, was the ultimate converged world—where dark matter, the stars, the black holes, the planets, the comets, well, just about everything, was one. Mankind, it has been conclusively proven, evolved from a converged world.

It is therefore apt that we are moving once again, technologically at least, toward a converged world—where more is less, and less is more. Where gadgets come together, and technologies meet halfway. We are coming full circle, so to speak.

Convergence can often be a daunting word, where more is misunderstood than understood. Trouble is, truly very little of it is understood. Is convergence limited to communication? How can convergence increase productivity at the workplace? And so on.

and tells you how much you have spent in the last month. It is connected to the camera at home so you can keep constant vigil. The Opium is also the one-stop GPS navigator, your one-stop connect to the unknown world in whatever country you are in. It is your interpreter, your communicator within an alien country; it gives you the latest currency rates, the sights to see, the people to meet, and the maps to reach them.

It allows you to make phone calls over the Internet. It allows you to download songs, videos and TV programmes, and broadcast video around the world. Corporations will video-conference with any other company around the world using wireless broadband, thus reducing air travel and creating an alternate cost structure for any company.

Well, you get the picture. The Opium will be a do-all gadget. I don’t know what shape it will take, and I daresay, even the most intrepid of artists would dither to make a prototype illustration.